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The Difficulties Faced by Researchers in Scholarly Publications. Case Study on the Researchers at Tahri Mohammed University of Bechar-Algeria

الصعوبات التي يواجهها الباحثون في المنشورات العلمية.

دراسة حول الباحثين في جامعة الطاهري محمد بشار-الجزائر

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Abstract:

Publishing scientific research is a complicated, sometimes confusing process that researchers, namely university lecturers and post-graduate students, often find challenging. This study aims to explore the existing difficulties that researchers face when submitting their manuscripts for scholarly publication. Moreover, it seeks to look for the researchers' attitudes towards these problems and their suggestions to overcome these difficulties. In order to answer the research questions, a questionnaire was distributed amongst researchers and lecturers at Tahrir Mohamed University of Bechar. The results attained from the study showed that the major difficulties that researchers face when submitting their manuscripts to both local and international journals include finding the appropriate journal for submission, funding and publishing fees, organizational obstacles and difficulties for obtaining the required data for the study. Based on the analysis of the data, the study argues that researchers' difficulties in scholarly publication may vary across faculties, qualifications, and researchers' expertise.

Keywords: Difficulties; journals; researchers; scientific research; scholarly publication.

المخلص:

إن نشر بحث علمي هو عملية معقدة، ومربكة وشاقة في بعض الأحيان، غالباً ما يجدها الباحثون صعبة. تهدف هذه الدراسة إلى استكشاف الصعوبات القائمة التي يواجهها الباحثون عند تقديم مقالاتهم للنشر العلمي. وتسعى إلى البحث عن مواقف الباحثين تجاه هذه المشاكل واقتراحاتهم للتغلب على هذه الصعوبات. للإجابة على أسئلة البحث، تم توزيع استبيان على الباحثين والمحاضرين في جامعة الطاهري محمد بشار. وأظهرت النتائج التي توصلت إليها الدراسة أن الصعوبات الرئيسية التي يواجهها الباحثون، عند تقديم مقالاتهم إلى المجلات المحلية والدولية على حد سواء، تشمل إيجاد المجلة المناسبة لتقديمها وتمويلها ورسوم نشرها، والعقبات التنظيمية والصعوبات في الحصول على البيانات المطلوبة للدراسة. واستناداً إلى تحليل البيانات، تجد الدراسة بأن الصعوبات التي يواجهها الباحثون في النشر العلمي قد تختلف باختلاف الكليات والمؤهلات والخبرات الفنية للباحثين.

الكلمات المفتاحية: صعوبات؛ المجلات؛ الباحثون؛ البحث العلمي؛ نشر علمي.

1. INTRODUCTION

In the realm of higher education and academic advancement, the publication of scientific research stands as a fundamental criterion for professional recognition, institutional evaluation, and knowledge dissemination. For university lecturers and postgraduate students, especially in developing academic contexts such as Algeria, scholarly publishing is not only a professional obligation but also a gateway to academic credibility and career progression.

However, despite the increasing emphasis placed on research productivity, many Algerian researchers encounter a wide array of difficulties throughout the publication process.

These challenges are not limited to the act of writing a scientific paper, which in itself demands academic rigor, originality, and methodological soundness. Rather, the complexity extends beyond the writing stage to include problems related to choosing the appropriate journal, adapting to various formatting templates, navigating submission

portals, responding to reviewers, managing long waiting periods, and dealing with publication fees. These obstacles often vary depending on whether the journal is national or international. While some national journals suffer from structural inefficiencies—such as unclear editorial timelines and inconsistent formatting requirements—international journals, although more organized, tend to impose additional technical demands (e.g., ORCID registration, detailed author guidelines, cover letters) and high processing fees, especially for high-impact publications.

The Algerian Ministry of Higher Education has introduced a journal classification system (categories A, B, and C) to help guide researchers in targeting reputable outlets. However, accessing A or B journals, particularly without financial support, remains a daunting task for many. Platforms such as *Green Journal*, developed by Professor Adala, have facilitated the process of identifying acceptable journals, but the issues of affordability, time constraints, and predatory publishing still persist.

Given this backdrop, the current study aims to explore the real-world difficulties encountered by researchers at Tahri Mohamed University of Bechar in their attempts to publish scholarly work. It also seeks to examine their perceptions of these challenges and gather their suggestions for overcoming them. The research specifically addresses the following questions:

1. What are the most common difficulties faced by researchers at Tahri Mohamed University of Bechar in publishing their scholarly work?
2. How do these challenges differ between national and international publishing contexts?

3. What are the researchers' attitudes toward these challenges?
4. What practical suggestions do researchers offer to improve the academic publishing experience?

2. LITERATURE REVIEW

Scholarly publications are the cornerstones of academic life, serving as critical means of communication, validation, and dissemination of research findings within and beyond the scholarly community. They are the documented outcomes of systematic investigation, creative inquiry, and analytical work (Saqr, Al-mohaimeed, & Rasheed, 2020). They appear in formats such as journal articles, conference proceedings, books, and chapters, and they often undergo rigorous peer review to ensure quality, credibility, and relevance (Starovoytova, 2017).

The act of publishing allows researchers and educators to share original findings, contribute to academic discourse, and push the boundaries of knowledge within their fields. By publishing, they contribute to the broader understanding of complex issues and can influence policy, practice, and further research (Peters et al, 2016). Furthermore, publishing in reputable journals helps to build the author's reputation within their academic community, allowing for more collaboration opportunities, grants, and invitations to conferences. Thus, high-impact publications can enhance the reputation of the institution as well, attracting talented students, faculty, and funding opportunities.

2.1. The Importance of Scholarly Publications

For researchers and university teachers, the process of publishing academic work is not merely an expectation but a vital part of their professional journey. It contributes to knowledge advancement, strengthens their academic reputation, and plays a significant

role in career development. For them, scholarly publication is much more than a formality; it is a dynamic platform for intellectual exchange and progress. By embracing this process, researchers and university teachers not only enrich their own professional development but also contribute to the collective wisdom that drives innovation and societal growth (Starovoytova, 2017). Thus, publishing offers a dual benefit. It not only enhances their expertise and teaching by connecting them with the latest developments in their discipline but also provides opportunities to inspire and guide their students with evidence-based knowledge. Furthermore, contributing to the academic literature can lead to collaborations, professional recognition, and increased funding opportunities.

However, navigating the complex landscape of scholarly publishing is not without its challenges. Researchers must adhere to stringent ethical standards, meet the expectations of journals and reviewers, and often contend with language barriers, funding issues, and limited institutional support. These obstacles underscore the importance of building a supportive academic environment that empowers scholars to succeed in sharing their valuable contributions.

According to Memon (2020), scholarly publishing plays an essential role in shaping a researcher's academic identity and reputation, especially in knowledge economies where research output is closely linked to institutional performance. In Algeria, recent educational reforms and Ministry directives have heightened the emphasis on research productivity, placing significant pressure on university lecturers and postgraduate students to publish in indexed or ranked journals. However, this

pressure is not matched by sufficient institutional support, infrastructure, or training, creating an imbalance that often leads to publication-related stress and academic burnout (Boudiaf & Abid, 2021).

2.2. The Complexity of the Publishing Process

The process of publishing a research article is rarely linear. Researchers often face challenges that go beyond writing and editing their manuscripts. These include selecting an appropriate journal, adhering to journal-specific formatting guidelines, undergoing rigorous peer review, and responding to reviewers' comments, all of which require time, patience, and guidance. Day & Gastel (2016) argue that early-career researchers, in particular, struggle with understanding submission protocols and the expectations of high-impact journals. Furthermore, many scholars from non-English-speaking countries, such as Algeria, must also overcome the language barrier, often translating their work into English or French to meet journal requirements. These technical and linguistic challenges increase the complexity of an already demanding process, especially in contexts with limited access to academic writing support or mentorship.

2.2.1. Structural and Editorial Issues in National Journals

One of the key obstacles reported by Algerian researchers relates to national journals. Many of these journals, although accessible, suffer from a lack of standardization in terms of formatting requirements, submission procedures, and editorial management. Each journal typically imposes its own template, often in complex formats that are not user-friendly, making manuscript submission a time-consuming and frustrating experience. As documented by Djebbour & Ziani (2019), the absence of

unified submission systems and the lack of digital editorial platforms in Algerian national journals discourage researchers and delay the publication process. Additionally, peer review in national journals is often inconsistent. Several researchers report waiting months, or even years, for a response from reviewers or editors, with no clear communication or transparency in the decision-making process. This lack of accountability not only affects the morale of researchers but also hampers academic progress, particularly for PhD students who are required to publish before graduation.

2.2.2. Barriers to International Publication

International journals are often perceived as more prestigious and better organized; however, they present a different set of challenges. Many high-quality journals require strict adherence to submission guidelines, including cover letters, author contribution forms, copyright declarations, and standardized referencing systems. Moreover, researchers are often expected to register with systems such as ORCID, ScholarOne, or Editorial Manager, which, although intended to streamline the submission process, are unfamiliar to many researchers in the Global South. As observed by Salager-Meyer (2008), the technical demands of international publishing are often underestimated by novice researchers, making the process appear daunting and inaccessible. One of the most significant challenges, however, lies in the cost of publication. Many reputable journals, particularly open-access ones, charge Article Processing Charges (APCs) that can exceed \$1,000—an amount unaffordable to most Algerian researchers who often lack institutional funding or grants. This financial barrier further marginalizes scholars from

lower-income countries and limits their visibility in global academic debates.

2.2.3. Predatory Journals: A Growing Threat to Research Integrity

The desire to publish quickly and the lack of awareness about reputable journals have led many Algerian researchers to fall victim to predatory journals. These journals, which claim to be peer-reviewed and indexed, often promise rapid publication in exchange for a fee, but they lack the editorial rigor and transparency of legitimate outlets. In some cases, researchers have unknowingly submitted to journals that are later blacklisted or removed from indexing databases such as Scopus or Web of Science. A case in point from this study involves researchers who published in a Brazilian journal that was later exposed as predatory, resulting in the loss of both their work and the money paid for publication. As Beall (2016) notes, the rise of predatory publishing disproportionately affects scholars in developing countries, where institutional oversight and publishing literacy are often limited. The long-term consequences include academic discreditation and the inability to use the article for promotion or graduation.

2.2.4. Journal Selection and the Role of Indexing Systems

Choosing the right journal is one of the most critical decisions in the publication process. In Algeria, this decision is heavily influenced by the Ministry of Higher Education's classification system, which categorizes journals into A, B, and C. Researchers are often encouraged to publish in A or B journals to maximize the academic weight of their work. However, these journals are not only highly selective but often charge publication fees, making them inaccessible to many researchers. To address this issue, Professor Adala developed the

Green Journal platform, which helps researchers identify indexed journals recognized by Algerian institutions. Although this tool has improved journal visibility and searchability, the problem of affordability and fit-for-purpose remains. According to Harzing & Alakangas (2017), indexing databases like Scimago Journal Rank (SJR) and DOAJ offer valuable tools for journal evaluation, but without proper training, researchers may still struggle to navigate them effectively.

2.2.5. Institutional Support, Training, and Research Culture

Another recurring theme in the literature is the lack of institutional support and publishing literacy. Many universities in Algeria do not offer regular workshops or training sessions on how to publish, choose journals, avoid predatory outlets, or navigate editorial systems. The absence of structured mentorship programs also means that early-career researchers must rely on personal effort or peer advice, which may not always be reliable. As noted by Lillis & Curry (2010), writing for academic publication is a social and collaborative practice that requires guidance and community support. Without targeted institutional interventions—such as academic writing centers, journal clubs, and peer-review training—researchers will continue to face the same difficulties across generations.

3. METHODOLOGY

3.1. Research Design

This study adopts a quantitative descriptive research design aimed at identifying and analyzing the main difficulties encountered by Algerian researchers in their attempts to publish scholarly work. The use of a structured questionnaire allowed for the systematic collection of data from a broad range of

participants across different faculties at TMUB. This methodological choice was particularly appropriate given the study's objective to gather consistent and comparable responses regarding publishing experiences, perceived challenges, and attitudes toward research publication. By analyzing quantifiable trends, the study aims to identify recurring patterns, significant obstacles, and context-specific problems that researchers in Algerian academic settings commonly face.

3.2. Participants and Sampling

The target population for this study consisted of academic researchers and university lecturers affiliated with various departments and faculties at TMUB. The sample included both early-career researchers (Master/Magister degree holders and doctoral candidates) and established scholars (PhD holders), representing faculties such as Letters and Foreign Languages, Science, Technology, Law, Economics, and Social Sciences. A purposive sampling technique was employed to ensure that only those directly involved in or familiar with the research publication process were included in the study. Participation was voluntary, and efforts were made to reach a balanced representation of both genders, disciplines, and qualification levels to ensure data diversity and relevance.

3.3. Instrumentation: The Questionnaire

Data were collected using an online questionnaire developed by the researchers and distributed via email and academic social networks. The questionnaire was composed of three main sections: Background Information, Difficulties of Scholarly Publications, and Researchers' Attitudes and Suggestions. The items were mostly closed-ended (e.g., multiple-choice, Yes/No questions), with a few open-ended prompts for elaboration, allowing participants to

provide illustrative examples or personal experiences. The questionnaire was designed to take approximately 10 to 15 minutes to complete, with clear instructions and concise wording to avoid ambiguity.

3.3.1. Section I: Background Information

This section gathered demographic and academic details such as gender, academic qualification (Master/Magister or Doctorate), and the respondent's faculty. These variables allowed for correlation between background factors and perceived challenges in publication.

3.3.2. Section II: Difficulties of Scholarly Publications

This core section investigated whether participants recognized the importance of scholarly publishing and whether they were engaged in the process. It also examined specific obstacles encountered in both local and international publication contexts. Items included barriers such as difficulty in selecting suitable journals, navigating complex formatting requirements, lack of feedback from editors, language constraints, and financial obstacles, particularly concerning publication fees in international journals.

3.3.3. Section III: Researchers' Attitudes and Suggestions

This section was designed to elicit respondents' views about institutional support, delays in the review process, and most importantly, recommendations for improving publishing practices. Open-ended questions invited participants to suggest strategies for overcoming publishing difficulties, including capacity-building measures like writing workshops and mentoring, as well as systemic improvements like streamlined submission platforms and improved access to resources.

3.4. Data Collection Procedure

The questionnaire was administered over a period of three weeks, during which participants were contacted through faculty mailing lists, WhatsApp research groups, and academic forums. All responses were collected anonymously to ensure confidentiality and encourage honest and accurate reporting of personal experiences. Completed questionnaires were automatically stored and compiled in Google Forms, then exported into Microsoft Excel for analysis.

4.RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

4.1.Results

This section presents the findings of the online questionnaire distributed to researchers at TMUB. The data are organized into three main sections based on the questionnaire structure: background information, difficulties in scholarly publication, and researchers' attitudes and suggestions.

The gender distribution in this study is relatively balanced, with a slight majority of male respondents (55%). In addition, the dominance of Doctorate holders (60%) is expected, given the nature of academic research activities. However, the significant presence of Master's holders (40%) suggests increasing involvement of early-career researchers in publication efforts.

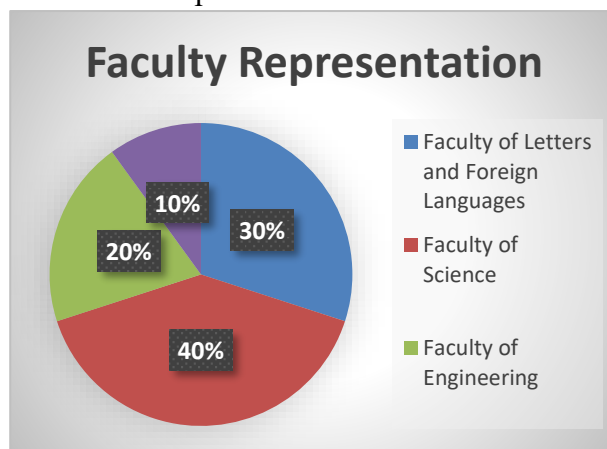


Figure 1: Faculty Distribution

The above figure highlights strong participation from scientific and technical fields, which often have higher publication expectations. Humanities and social sciences are also well represented.

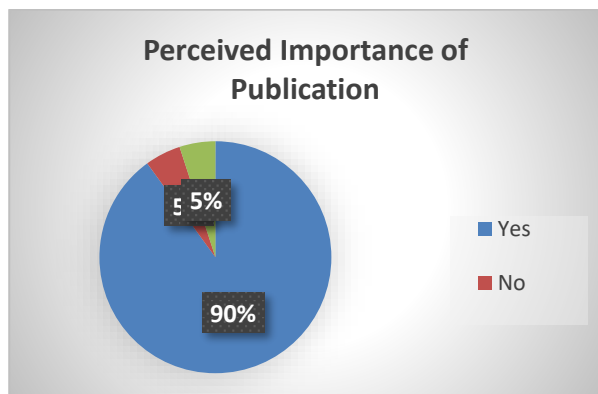


Figure 2: Perceived Importance of Publication

According to the above figure, a strong consensus (90%) affirms that publishing is critical for career progression and academic credibility. This aligns with global academic trends. When asked about their interest in publishing, although most researchers (85%) are enthusiastic about publishing, a minority feel discouraged due to structural and procedural challenges. Reasons for disinterest are the overwhelming process and the lack of institutional support, among several other reasons.

The following table summarises the results of the participants' publication history:

Table 1.

Publication History

Publication Type	Percentage
Local Journals	35%
International Journals	25%
International Book	10%
Local Book	5%
International Conference Proceedings	15%

Local Conference Proceedings	10%
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The analysis of the publication history of researchers, as shown in the table above, reveals a noticeable disparity between local and international publishing outputs. Local journal publications represent the highest proportion at 35%, followed by international journal publications at 25%. While a notable percentage of researchers have managed to publish in international conference proceedings (15%) and international books (10%), the relatively lower figures for local books (5%) and local conference proceedings (10%) suggest limited engagement in these formats. This distribution highlights a preference—or perhaps greater accessibility—toward local journal outlets, possibly due to fewer language barriers, lower costs, and more familiar institutional expectations. However, this also reflects a wider issue: despite the recognized value of international visibility, local researchers face substantial hurdles that limit their participation in global scholarly discourse.

These patterns can be further understood when examined alongside the obstacles reported by researchers. For local publications, the primary barrier is the difficulty in obtaining adequate research resources, reported by 40% of respondents. This includes limited access to academic databases, funding, research tools, and institutional support. Another significant challenge is identifying appropriate journals for submission (30%), which is further complicated by the lack of standardized submission procedures across local journals—each often requiring articles to be formatted according to specific and sometimes confusing templates. Additionally, 20% of participants mentioned

editorial delays and peer review issues, highlighting inefficiencies in the publication pipeline, including unresponsive editors, lack of qualified reviewers, and extended review periods. Only 10% of respondents considered topic selection a major challenge in local publishing, indicating that researchers generally feel confident in developing suitable research questions, but are hindered more by structural limitations than intellectual ones.

In the international context, the most pressing barrier identified is funding, reported by 30% of respondents. Publishing in reputable international journals often involves costly article processing charges (APCs), which are unaffordable for many Algerian researchers due to limited institutional or governmental financial support. This problem is compounded by the scarcity of resources (25%), especially access to updated literature, advanced software, and collaborative research opportunities. Moreover, 20% of participants highlighted the challenge of locating appropriate journals, which in international publishing is a time-consuming and complex process due to the diversity of scopes, impact factors, and submission requirements. Interestingly, topic selection remains a secondary issue internationally (15%), similar to local publishing. However, language proficiency and communication barriers represent a unique obstacle in the international sphere, with 10% of researchers citing difficulties in writing manuscripts in academic English or navigating submission platforms in foreign languages.



Figure 3: Suggested Solutions for Publication

When asked to propose practical solutions to the challenges they face in scholarly publication, researchers at TMUB highlighted a strong need for structural and institutional reform. The most frequently mentioned solution, chosen by 40% of the respondents, is to improve funding for research and publication. This reflects the widespread concern over limited financial support, especially for international publication where article processing charges and research expenses can be prohibitively high. The lack of accessible funding discourages many researchers from even attempting to submit their work to indexed or high-impact journals. Therefore, there is a clear demand for national or institutional funding schemes dedicated specifically to supporting publication fees, purchasing software or datasets, and covering the costs of translation or editing services.

The second most suggested solution, supported by 30% of participants, is the organization of institutional workshops on academic writing and the publication process. This highlights a recognized need for capacity-building initiatives. Many researchers, especially early-career academics, struggle with structuring articles, writing in an academic tone, crafting effective cover letters, or understanding peer

review procedures. Practical workshops—especially if offered regularly and led by experienced scholars—could bridge this knowledge gap and increase the overall quality and publishability of research outputs.

In addition, 20% of the respondents advocate for encouraging international collaboration. This solution is both forward-thinking and strategic, as collaboration with foreign institutions or researchers can enhance the quality, credibility, and visibility of research. It also provides access to new ideas, methodologies, and sometimes even shared funding or journal networks. Collaborations may help local researchers overcome the isolation often associated with academic work in under-resourced institutions. However, such partnerships require institutional frameworks that support exchange programs, joint research projects, or co-publication agreements.

Lastly, 10% of respondents suggested simplifying journal submission and review procedures, particularly in local publishing contexts. Many Algerian journals lack streamlined, user-friendly platforms, and each journal often imposes different technical and formatting requirements. This inconsistency not only creates confusion but also consumes considerable time and effort. By unifying or standardizing submission guidelines, automating editorial workflows, and offering clear communication, local journals could significantly reduce the burden on researchers and encourage more frequent and confident submissions.

4.2. Discussion

The results clearly highlight that scholarly publishing is considered a fundamental part of academic life by the vast majority of respondents. However, despite this shared recognition, many face substantial

structural and procedural barriers. This aligns with findings by Tardy (2004), who argued that institutional support and access to resources are essential determinants of publishing success, particularly in under-resourced academic environments.

In comparison to studies such as Canagarajah (2002), which emphasized the difficulties faced by researchers from the periphery in publishing in mainstream journals, the present findings similarly show that Algerian researchers struggle with visibility, funding, and procedural requirements. The need for advanced writing skills, ORCID setup, proper cover letters, and knowledge of submission systems continues to be a major burden, especially in international contexts.

Interestingly, the respondents' split opinions on faculty support reflect institutional inconsistency. As Lillis and Curry (2010) observed, institutional engagement is often uneven in the Global South, leading to fragmented support systems. Moreover, the long response times from journals, noted by 70% of the participants, echo global frustrations regarding peer review delays and opacity in editorial decision-making (Ware & Mabe, 2015).

On a positive note, the suggestions provided by respondents show a clear understanding of what is needed: financial support, technical training, and international mentorship. These align with recommendations by Flowerdew (2000), who advocated capacity-building strategies to empower researchers in English-as-an-additional-language (EAL) settings.

5. CONCLUSION

The findings of this study shed important light on the multifaceted challenges Algerian researchers face in their

pursuit of scholarly publication, with a particular focus on the academic community at TMUB. While most researchers clearly recognize the significance of publishing in advancing their academic careers, they remain constrained by both structural and procedural barriers. The study highlights key difficulties such as the lack of funding, the complexity of identifying suitable journals, inconsistencies in local journal submission formats, and long delays in editorial decisions. These challenges are further compounded when attempting to publish internationally, where additional hurdles such as language barriers, unfamiliarity with submission protocols, and high publication fees persist.

It is evident from the data that researchers are not lacking in motivation or research activity; rather, they are navigating a publication landscape that is fragmented and, in many cases, unsupportive. The equal split in faculty support for publication, as well as the significant percentage of researchers who spend excessive time awaiting journal responses, suggests a pressing need for institutional reform. Moreover, the risk of publishing in predatory journals—especially when driven by desperation or lack of guidance—reveals the vulnerability of researchers in a competitive global academic environment.

Encouragingly, the respondents proposed a number of constructive solutions. These include increased funding for research and publication, institutional workshops to enhance academic writing skills, fostering international collaborations, and streamlining journal submission procedures. Such recommendations, if implemented, could significantly improve both the quantity and quality of scholarly output among Algerian researchers.

In conclusion, the advancement of academic research in Algeria depends not only on the individual commitment of researchers but also on the establishment of robust institutional and national frameworks that support, guide, and value scholarly publication. This study calls for coordinated action by universities, ministries, and academic bodies to remove existing barriers and foster a more inclusive and productive research culture. Only then can Algerian scholars fully participate in and contribute to the global body of academic knowledge.

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